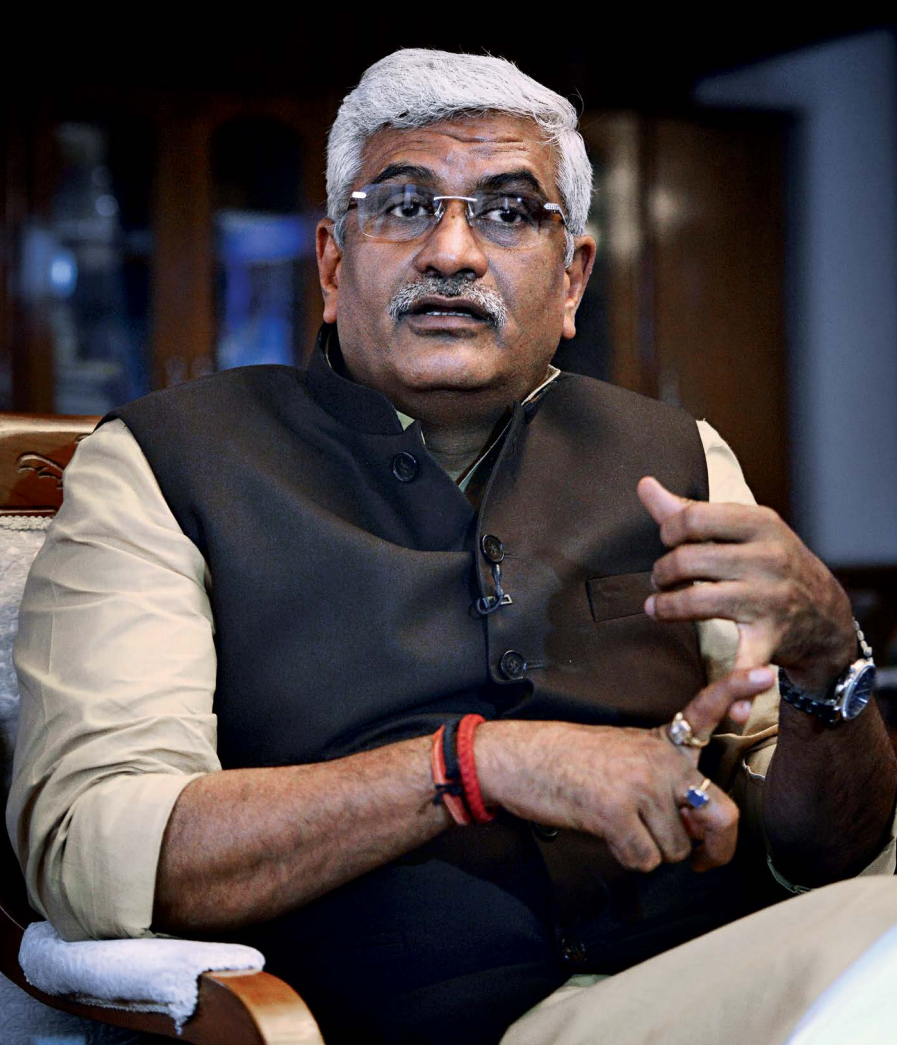


CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Gehlot's ultimate failure was the 2022 murder of tailor Kanhaiya Lal in Udaipur [a fallout of the controversy over BJP leader Nupur Sharma's comments on the Prophet]. There are law and order issues too. Rajasthan is a state known for its respect for women, but now it has become the rape capital of India. The sand mining gangs are being run by Congress leaders and so is the land, drugs and liquor mafia.

Q. You accuse the Congress of patronising criminals but then induct Giriraj Singh Malinga, a former Congress MLA who is accused of assaulting a Dalit engineer. You have also given him a party ticket...

A. We weighed the pros and cons. The case against him is false and the benefit of having him with us is that we will win 3-4 seats in the Dholpur area where we could not have won any.

Q. Gehlot has made the Eastern River Canal Project (ERCP) a major issue, blaming the Centre for denying water to 13 districts. Does it worry you?

A. It's a total misinformation campaign. He is bent upon maligning me and Modiji, even called me *nikamma* (useless) for not getting it declared a national project. The PM has assured us that he will look into the ERCP technicalities favourably. Gehlot keeps demanding national status for it, but for that it needs to pass certain criteria. We asked Rajasthan to revise the project report to ensure 75 per cent dependability, which it never did. The PM has suggested that we take a different approach to the issue. I had worked out a new project report where Rajasthan would get as much water and the state would have to pay just Rs 800 crore, rather than the original Rs 40,000 crore. But again the Congress government has not shown any interest. Instead, the Gehlot government rushed through tenders worth some Rs 14,000 crore, which is another scam.

"THE PROMISES GEHLOT MADE BEFORE THE LAST ELECTION HAVE NOT BEEN FULFILLED, NOR HAVE ANY OF THE BIG PROJECTS BEEN COMPLETED...IT'S ALL A BIG SCAM"

Q. Your ministry launched the Jal Jeevan Mission but its implementation has been slow in the state. Why?

A. Rajasthan, for unexplained reasons, was slow to start with it, despite being a state with one of the lowest numbers of drinking water connections. We gave it enough funds, keeping in mind cost and the long distances. But while the national average has risen from 16 per cent when we began the project to 70 per cent, Rajasthan has grown from 11.5 per cent to 40 per cent. And they have issued tenders worth Rs 40,000 crore, of which about Rs 18,000 crore is under the ED scanner now.

Q. The BJP has so far run a negative campaign. What is the new Rajasthan it is promising if it comes to power?

A. Rajasthan can be the growth engine for Modi's vision. The state has the best land to human ratio, so much raw material including minerals, crude oil, enough electricity, logistics, infrastructure and even water. For instance, I propose setting up a wet port in Sanchore by having a 350-km-long canal from the Rann of Kutch which can transport loads worth 50,000 trucks a day. That will bring industry and create employment in a state known for its entrepreneurship and skills. ■